

AP World History: Modern The Complete Exam Guide

All 9 units explained, the SAQ, DBQ and LEQ playbook with a sample thesis, the historical thinking skills, and 10 hard source-based practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.

**3:15**

hours total,
including reading time

55+5

multiple-choice +
written questions

25%

of your score is
the DBQ alone

64–66%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Two sections, four tasks

Your AP score (1–5) combines multiple choice, short answers and two essays. Most tasks are source-based, covering world history from about 1200 to the present.

40%

MCQ · 55 questions

20%

SAQ · 3 questions

25%

DBQ · 1 essay

15%

LEQ

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
IA · Multiple choice	40% of score 55 minutes 55 questions	Sets of usually 3–4 questions built around a primary or secondary source: texts, images, charts or maps.
IB · Short answer	20% of score 40 minutes 3 questions	Q1 (secondary source or sources) and Q2 (primary source) are required; then choose Q3 or Q4 (no source). Each has three parts.
II · Document-based question	25% of score 60 min (incl. 15-min reading) 1 essay	Write an argument using 7 documents plus your own knowledge. The DBQ covers 1450–2001.
II · Long essay	15% of score 40 minutes 1 essay	Choose one of three prompts, each covering a different span of time periods, and write an argument.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

SCORED WITH RUBRICS

Essays use the same rubric every year

The DBQ (7 points) and long essay (6 points) are scored on thesis, contextualization, evidence and analysis. Learning the rubric is the fastest way to raise your score.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 15 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.

SECTION I

02 Multiple choice & short answer

55 multiple-choice questions in 55 minutes (one minute each), then 3 short-answer questions in 40 minutes. Most questions use a source.

55

source-based multiple-choice questions

1:00

minute per multiple-choice question

3

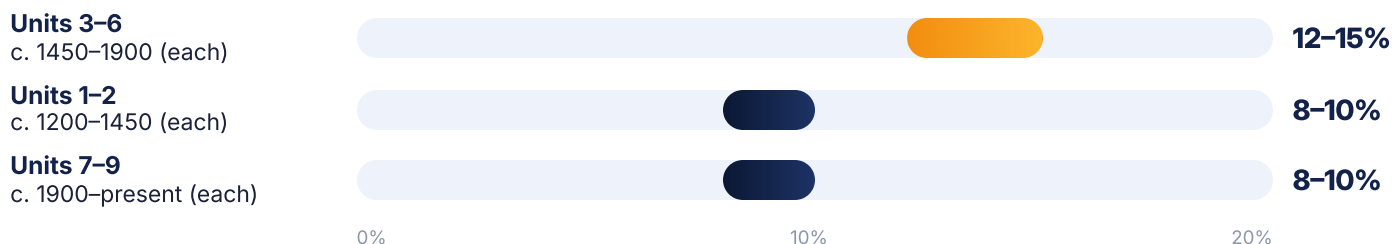
short-answer questions, 3 parts each

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

How the exam is weighted by unit

College Board gives a range for each unit's share of the exam. Bars show minimum to maximum.

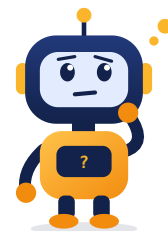


What this means for your study time: Units 3–6 (about 1450–1900) carry the most weight: empires, oceanic exchange, revolutions and industrialization. That is where most essays come from too.

Strategies for multiple choice and short answers

- Read the source line first: author, date and audience tell you the context before you read the text.
- Answer the question asked. "Which development most directly caused..." means a cause, not just a related event.
- For short answers, use ACE: Answer the question, Cite specific evidence, Explain how it supports your answer.
- One part, one paragraph. Label each short-answer part (a), (b), (c) and answer in 2–3 sentences.
- Be specific: name people, laws, events and dates. Vague answers rarely earn the point.
- Never leave a blank. Guess, flag and move on at the one-minute mark.

Short answers need **specific evidence**. "There were reforms" scores nothing; naming one reform can.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 9 units, in plain English

Everything on the exam fits into these units.

UNIT 1 8–10%	The Global Tapestry c. 1200–1450 Know: Song China; Dar al-Islam; South and Southeast Asia; states in the Americas and Africa; feudal Europe.	UNIT 2 8–10%	Networks of Exchange c. 1200–1450 Know: the Silk Roads; the Mongol Empire; Indian Ocean and trans-Saharan trade; the spread of religions, technologies and disease.
UNIT 3 12–15%	Land-Based Empires c. 1450–1750 Know: the Ottoman, Safavid, Mughal and Qing empires; how rulers legitimized and consolidated power; gunpowder empires.	UNIT 4 12–15%	Transoceanic Interconnections c. 1450–1750 Know: maritime exploration; the Columbian Exchange; the Atlantic slave trade; colonial labor systems; resistance to European expansion.
UNIT 5 12–15%	Revolutions c. 1750–1900 Know: the Enlightenment; the American, French, Haitian and Latin American revolutions; nationalism; the Industrial Revolution's origins.	UNIT 6 12–15%	Consequences of Industrialization c. 1750–1900 Know: new imperialism; resistance to imperialism; migration; economic imperialism; global effects of industrial growth.
UNIT 7 8–10%	Global Conflict c. 1900–present Know: causes and effects of World War I; the interwar period and Great Depression; totalitarian states; World War II and genocide.	UNIT 8 8–10%	Cold War & Decolonization c. 1900–present Know: superpower rivalry and proxy wars; decolonization in Asia and Africa; new states; movements for civil rights and independence.
UNIT 9 8–10%	Globalization c. 1900–present Know: advances in technology and medicine; environmental change; economic globalization; social movements; international organizations.		

● The historical thinking skills

Sourcing

Analyze point of view, purpose, audience and situation.

Contextualization

Place an event in its broader historical setting.

Comparison

Explain similarities and differences.

Causation & CCOT

Explain causes, effects, continuity and change.

SECTION II

04 The DBQ & the long essay

100 minutes for two essays. Both are scored with fixed rubrics, so you can practice for exactly what earns points.

Thesis 1

Context 1

Evidence 3

Analysis & reasoning 2

DBQ rubric: 7 points. The long essay uses the same rows but 2 evidence points (6 in total).

DBQ

Document-based question

7 points • 60 minutes

Use at least **4 documents** to support an argument for full evidence credit, add one piece of **outside evidence**, and explain **sourcing** for at least 2 documents.

Group documents into 2–3 categories that each prove part of your thesis.

LEQ

Long essay question

6 points • 40 minutes

No documents: the evidence comes from your own knowledge. Choose the prompt carefully, then argue a clear line of reasoning.

Pick the prompt for which you know the most specific evidence.

Th

Thesis (1 point)

Historically defensible claim

One or two sentences that make a claim and set out a line of reasoning. It can be in the introduction or conclusion.

"Although X, Y mainly because A and B" shows complexity from the start.

Cx

Contextualization (1 point)

The bigger picture

Describe broader developments before, during or after the period that relate to the prompt, in several sentences.

Write it as your opening paragraph so you don't forget it.

◆ A time plan for the 100 minutes

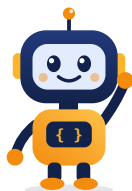
Read docs
15 min

Write DBQ
45 min

Plan
LEQ
5 min

Write LEQ
35 min

The 15-minute reading period is built into the recommended 60 minutes for the DBQ.



The **complexity point** is the hardest. Earn it by analyzing multiple variables, qualifying your argument, or connecting across periods.

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

05

Anatomy of a strong DBQ

Here is a DBQ-style prompt, a strong opening and one body paragraph, annotated to show where points come from.

PRACTICE TASK · WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (DBQ style): Evaluate the extent to which the Columbian Exchange transformed societies in the Americas, Europe and Africa from 1450 to 1750. *(Sample paragraph references hypothetical documents.)*

Sample opening and body paragraph

① Before 1492, the Eastern and Western Hemispheres had developed largely separate crops, animals and diseases, and trade networks such as the Indian Ocean routes connected Afro-Eurasia but not the Americas.

② **Thesis:** The Columbian Exchange transformed all three regions, devastating Indigenous populations in the Americas, feeding population growth in Europe, and drawing Africa into the Atlantic slave trade, although many local political and cultural traditions persisted.

③ Disease was the most destructive force. Document 2, a Spanish friar's account, describes towns emptied by smallpox.

④ As a missionary who criticized colonists' abuses, the friar may have stressed suffering to persuade the Crown to protect Indigenous people. ⑤ As Indigenous labor under the encomienda collapsed, the Spanish turned increasingly to enslaved Africans.

- ① **Contextualization** sets up the broader situation before the thesis.
- ② **Thesis** makes a defensible claim with a line of reasoning.
- ③ **Document evidence** is used to *support* a point, not just summarized.
- ④ **Sourcing** explains why the author's purpose or point of view matters.
- ⑤ **Outside evidence** adds a specific fact not in the documents.

Five habits for every history essay

1

Underline every task verb in the prompt before you plan.

2

Write a defensible thesis in your first paragraph.

3

Back every claim with specific evidence, then explain it.

4

Keep 2 minutes to reread and fix unclear sentences.

5

Stuck? Answer each part separately in order. Partial credit is real.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Just **summarize** each document! (Don't.)



01 Restating the prompt as a thesis

A thesis must take a position and give reasons. Repeating the question earns no point.

02 Listing documents

"Document 1 says... Document 2 says..." is summary. Use documents as evidence for your argument.

03 Sourcing by labeling

"The author is a merchant" isn't enough. Explain **how** that affects the document's message.

04 One-sentence context

Contextualization needs several sentences about the broader situation, connected to the prompt.

05 Outside evidence from the documents

Outside evidence must be a specific fact that is **not** in any document.

06 Wrong time period

Evidence from outside the prompt's dates doesn't count. Check the years before writing.

07 Vague SAQ answers

Short answers need a specific example and an explanation, not a general statement.

08 Running out of time on the DBQ

Watch the clock. A rushed LEQ costs more than a slightly shorter DBQ.

09 Presentism

Judge events by their own time's context, and avoid "always" or "never" claims.

10 Skipping the conclusion

A conclusion is a second chance to state the thesis or earn the complexity point.

Quick self-check: can you compare how the Ottoman and Qing empires legitimized their rule, and explain one way the Industrial Revolution drove new imperialism? If not, review Units 3 and 6.

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May



A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Shift the months to match your teacher's pacing, and write at least one timed essay every two weeks.

Sep – Oct

c. 1200–1450



Units 1–2

States and trade networks before 1450. Practice comparison: two empires, one similarity, one difference.

Nov – Dec

c. 1450–1750



Units 3–4

heavy units

Land-based empires and oceanic exchange. Write your first short answers and a practice DBQ.

Jan – Feb

c. 1750–1900



Units 5–6

Revolutions, industrialization and imperialism. A timed DBQ every two weeks.

Mar – Apr

c. 1900–present



Units 7–9

World wars, Cold War, decolonization and globalization. Alternate DBQs and long essays.

Early May

Sharpen



Full timed sections

Full Section I and both essays under timing. Review the rubric and traps list.

Exam day

May



AP World exam • Bluebook

Sleep well, charge your device, and use the checklist at the end of this guide.

• The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: one timed DBQ plus 28 multiple-choice questions	List your two weakest periods
3 weeks out	Review weak periods; write one SAQ set daily	Specific evidence in every answer
2 weeks out	Full 3-hour-15-minute practice exam	Finish all four tasks on time
Final week	Light review: rubric, key turning points, traps list	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original source-based questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Give yourself **15 minutes** for all ten, then check page 11.

1 UNIT 2 • CAUSATION

The expansion of the Mongol Empire in the 1200s most directly contributed to which development?

- A The decline of trade along the Silk Roads
- B Increased transfer of goods, technologies and disease across Eurasia
- C The end of the Islamic caliphates in Spain
- D The beginning of the Atlantic slave trade

2 UNIT 2 • COMPARISON

Trade in the Indian Ocean before 1450 differed from trade along the Silk Roads mainly because Indian Ocean trade:

- A was controlled by a single empire
- B moved only luxury goods
- C had no role in spreading religion
- D relied on monsoon winds and carried larger quantities of bulk goods

3 UNIT 3 • COMPARISON

The Ottoman devshirme system and the Qing use of the civil service exam were similar in that both:

- A excluded all non-elite people from government
- B were based on Christian teaching
- C were ways of recruiting loyal officials for the state
- D were introduced by European advisers

4 UNIT 4 • CAUSATION

Which factor best explains the rapid growth of the Atlantic slave trade after 1600?

- A Demand for labor on plantations in the Americas after Indigenous populations collapsed
- B The decline of sugar plantations
- C The end of the Columbian Exchange
- D Industrial factories in Africa

5 UNIT 5 • SOURCING

"Men are born and remain free and equal in rights. Social distinctions may be founded only upon the general good."

Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen, France, 1789

The ideas in the excerpt were most directly used by which group in the years that followed?

- A Absolute monarchs defending divine right
- B Qing officials resisting British trade
- C Enslaved people and free people of color in Saint-Domingue fighting for rights
- D Japanese samurai opposing the Meiji Restoration

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

6 UNIT 6 • CAUSATION

Which was a major reason industrializing states expanded their empires in the late 1800s?

- A A decline in nationalism
- B A need for raw materials and new markets
- C The end of the steamship era
- D The spread of communism

7 UNIT 6 • CONTINUITY & CHANGE

Which statement best describes a change in global migration in the 1800s?

- A Migration stopped because of industrialization
- B Migration was mostly from the Americas to Europe
- C Forced migration through the Atlantic slave trade increased sharply after 1850
- D Large numbers of indentured laborers moved from Asia to plantations around the world

8 UNIT 7 • CAUSATION

Which best explains why the Treaty of Versailles contributed to instability in Germany after World War I?

- A It imposed heavy reparations and war guilt, fueling economic hardship and resentment
- B It gave Germany new colonies in Africa
- C It created the United Nations
- D It ended the Russian Revolution

9 UNIT 8 • COMPARISON

Independence movements in India and in Algeria differed most in that:

- A Algeria gained independence before India
- B India remained a French colony
- C India's independence was largely achieved through nonviolent mass protest, while Algeria's involved a long armed war
- D Neither movement was influenced by nationalism

10 UNIT 9 • CAUSATION

Which development most directly increased the speed of economic globalization after 1950?

- A The decline of container shipping
- B New communication and transportation technologies, along with lower trade barriers
- C A worldwide return to the gold standard
- D The end of all international organizations

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	B	The Pax Mongolica made long-distance travel safer, increasing exchange of goods, ideas, technologies, and diseases such as the plague.
2	D	Monsoon winds allowed predictable sea routes that could carry bulk goods. Overland Silk Road trade focused more on high-value luxury goods.
3	C	Both recruited officials whose loyalty and skill served the state: devshirme through levies of Christian boys, the exams through merit-based testing.
4	A	Disease and harsh labor collapsed Indigenous populations; plantation owners, especially in sugar, turned to enslaved Africans for labor.
5	C	The Haitian Revolution drew on these revolutionary ideals of liberty and equality, leading to the first successful slave revolt and independent Black republic.
6	B	Industrial economies needed raw materials such as rubber and cotton, and new markets for manufactured goods.
7	D	After the abolition of slavery, indentured laborers from India and China migrated to plantations in the Caribbean, Africa and the Pacific.
8	A	Reparations and the war-guilt clause contributed to economic crisis and resentment that extremist parties, including the Nazis, exploited.
9	C	India's movement used mass nonviolent protest under Gandhi; Algeria fought a long, violent war against France (1954–1962).
10	B	Container shipping, jet travel and later the internet, together with trade agreements, rapidly increased global economic integration.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Re-learn the turning points of each period and practice sourcing.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 64–66% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP World History: Modern, and about 14% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

64–66%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

14%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Plan your time: **1 min** per multiple-choice question, **~13 min** per short answer, **60 min** for the DBQ and **40 min** for the long essay
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Memorize the **DBQ and LEQ rubric rows**
- ☐ Practice typing a full essay in 40 minutes before exam day

In the essays: open with context, state a defensible thesis with reasons, use documents as evidence with sourcing, add specific outside evidence, and explain how every piece supports your argument.



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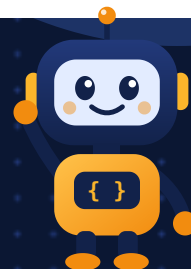
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Write DBQs, long essays and short answers and get them scored against the real rubric.

Timed exam practice

Full-length multiple-choice sets with score reports, so you see progress before May.

◆ Contact us

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